level could be strengthened and sustained. Trust and respect were mutual. He was prepared to put the hours into me.

International sport can play out frantically, because of the exposure it commands. My mentor continued to deal in quiet certainties. Some days you get out, some days you don't. Take the long-term view. When I got a low score, he would seek to reassure rather than accuse. 'We'll work hard tomorrow,' he'd say. 'Don't look back.'

There were other, better, technical coaches, but no one could rival his understanding of the mechanics of building an innings, the subtleties of game management. Sport is cyclical; he was passing on the formative lessons he'd learned under Ken Barrington and developed in partnership with Geoffrey Boycott.

He used to talk about 'The Knowledge'. This encompassed the power of concentration, the importance of building a firm base before becoming too expansive. He taught me to study the weather as well as the wicket, and to make sure I was mentally secure in what I was seeking to achieve.

His priority was to make me play positively. He liked it when I was ambitious, looking to score runs rather than merely survive. His logic was, as usual, easy to follow: if you seek the initiative, you are transferring the pressure to the bowler. Don't give him the respite of shuffling about, soaking up thirty or forty balls for the odd run.

Work hard. Earn the right to play. Trust in your talent and preparation. Groove your movements. Pick up the line. Hit the ball back where it came from. Send the message to the bowler that you know what you are doing. One dog-stick drill summarized the simplicity of the process: I had to do one of three things, drive the ball, leave the ball or execute a forward defensive shot.

Perhaps he had worked out that I was uncomfortable with lavish praise. When I did well, scoring a century or putting into practice something on which we had worked, he knew all I needed was a nod, the odd word. When we made technical changes, I usually made the first move after a lot of contemplation.

It is a dangerous period – you have only to look at the number of golfers whose fortunes have nosedived after making a fundamental swing change. Habits are deeply ingrained and resistant to anything more than gentle evolution over time. In my case, I looked a lot taller at the crease, more natural, when I was with the Under-19s.